5

Institutions and Strategic Culture

FOR SEVERAL YEARS after Independence, India's leaders saw external relations as being mainly about diplomatic stature, not about competing interests and strategies. Nehru waxed eloquent about India's special position in the world but as K. Subrahmanyam points out, 'the much needed synergy for effective national security management', involving interaction of different components of the security establishment, was totally absent.[1] India's vision of its place in the world, its historic civilization, the writings of its ancient philosophers and actions of its medieval kings, as well as the policies of its Western colonizers, failed to bequeath a uniquely Indian strategic culture.

Jaswant Singh, who served both as minister of defence and as minister for external affairs at different times, pointed out that India sits at the crossroads of four collapsed empires – the Chinese, Ottoman, British and Russian – while its security challenges are defined by four lines – McMahon Line, Durand Line, Line of Actual Control, and Line of Control.[2] Influenced by other empires and circumscribed by boundaries drawn by outsiders, India lacks a clear set of beliefs, attitudes and norms about the use of force or defining its frontiers that could be described as exclusively Indian.